**QUESTION 1**

# villain

(in a film, novel, or play)
A character whose evil actions or motives are important to the plot.

# victim

A person harmed, injured, or killed as a result of a crime, accident, or other event.
A person who is tricked or duped.
A person who has come to feel helpless and passive in the face of misfortune or ill-treatment.
*Consider the above definitions.*

1. Analyse whether you believe Lady Macbeth is the villain, or victim, of this story.

# Deconstructing the essay topic

Essay question:

## Analyse whether you believe Lady Macbeth is the villain, or victim, of this story.

### Step 1: Identify the instruction word

### ANALYSE

Explain the topic in detail by examining Lady Macbeth's actions, motivations and experiences. Consider the evidence and explore what it reveals about her character.

Students should do more than describe what Lady Macbeth does. They must explain why she acts as she does and how her actions or experiences influence her fate.

### Step 2: Understand the key terms

VILLAIN

A character who causes harm through evil actions or intentions.

Students could consider:

- Lady Macbeth's ambition and desire for power.
- Her manipulation of Macbeth.
- Her encouragement of Duncan's murder.
- Her willingness to put power above morality.

VICTIM

A person who suffers harm or becomes powerless in the face of misfortune or ill-treatment.

Students could consider:

- The influence of the expectations placed on women in Shakespeare's society.
- Her role in encouraging Macbeth and the consequences of their choices.
- Her growing guilt and mental distress.
- Her loss of control and inability to escape the consequences of her actions.

### Step 3: Explore the word OR

The word OR is particularly important because it asks students to consider two different interpretations of Lady Macbeth.

They should decide whether she is primarily a villain, primarily a victim, or a combination of both.

| Argument | Possible central idea |
| --- | --- |
| Lady Macbeth is the villain. | She actively encourages evil and helps set the tragedy in motion. |
| Lady Macbeth is the victim. | She becomes overwhelmed by guilt and suffers the consequences of her choices. |
| Lady Macbeth is both. | She is responsible for her actions, but those actions ultimately contribute to her own destruction. |

Students do not have to argue that both sides are equally convincing. They must develop a clear argument and support it with evidence from the play.

## Step 4: Identify the evidence

Students should select three key points that support their argument. For example:

Point 1

Her ambition

How does Lady Macbeth respond to the possibility of Macbeth becoming king? Does her desire for power influence her moral choices?

Point 2

Her influence over Macbeth

How does she persuade Macbeth to murder Duncan? To what extent is she responsible for his actions?

Point 3

Her guilt and downfall

How does Lady Macbeth change after Duncan's murder? Does her suffering make her a victim, or is it the consequence of her own choices?

## Step 5: Formulate a thesis

The thesis is the student's overall answer to the question. It must state their position clearly.

Here are three possible approaches:

- Villain: Lady Macbeth is primarily a villain because her ambition, manipulation of Macbeth and willingness to encourage murder demonstrate her moral corruption.
- Victim: Lady Macbeth can be viewed as a victim because her desire for power, the expectations placed on her and her eventual psychological suffering contribute to her tragic fate.

- Both: Lady Macbeth is both a villain and a victim because she actively contributes to Duncan's murder, yet ultimately becomes a victim of the guilt and consequences that follow.

# A useful checklist for students

Before writing, students should be able to answer these questions:

- ☐ Have I clearly stated whether I consider Lady Macbeth a villain, a victim, or both?
- ☐ Have I selected three relevant points to support my argument?
- ☐ Have I used specific evidence from the play?
- ☐ Have I explained how each example supports my argument?
- ☐ Have I considered both her responsibility for her actions and the suffering she experiences?

The most important distinction: Students must not simply retell the plot. They must use Lady Macbeth's actions and experiences to evaluate whether she deserves to be seen as a villain, a victim, or both.

## QUESTION 1

villain

- (in a film, novel, or play)
- A character whose evil actions or motives are important to the plot.

victim

A person harmed, injured, or killed as a result of a crime, accident, or other event.
A person who is tricked or duped.
A person who has come to feel helpless and passive in the face of misfortune or ill-treatment.
*Consider the above definitions.*

Analyse whether you believe Lady Macbeth is the villain, or victim, of this story.

**STEP-BY-STEP FORMULA FOR AN INTRODUCTION**

- Name the text and author - always start by mentioning the title of the text (underlined) and the author.
- Show you understand the topic -restate the essay question or theme in your own words.
- Mention 2–3 key points you will discuss - briefly point to the moments, characters, or ideas you will analyse in your essay.
- Give a clear thesis (your main argument) - make a direct statement about how you plan to unpack this topic.

**FORMULA IN PRACTICE**

In [text] by [author], [theme/character/idea] is important because [short explanation]. This is shown through [point 1], [point 2], and [point 3]. Together, these moments reveal [your thesis/argument].

**MAKE SURE YOUR INTRODUCTION DOES THREE THINGS:**

✔ Tells the reader what text you're writing about,
✔ Shows you understand the question/theme,
✔ Makes it clear what your argument will be (your stance).

## WRITE THE INTRODUCTION FOR QUESTION 1

**VILLAIN** perspective:

Example introduction

In Macbeth by William Shakespeare, Lady Macbeth is portrayed as the villain because her ambition and desire for power lead her to abandon her moral values. This is shown through her determination to persuade Macbeth to murder King Duncan, her manipulation of Macbeth by questioning his courage and masculinity, and her willingness to help conceal their crime after the murder. Together, these actions reveal that Lady Macbeth is a ruthless and manipulative character who plays a significant role in the tragedy.

✔ Her determination to plan Duncan's murder

Lady Macbeth believes that Macbeth must become king and is willing to use murder to achieve this ambition. She calls on supernatural forces to remove her compassion and make her cruel.

Key evidence: "unsex me here" (Act 1, Scene 5).

Lady Macbeth's determination to become queen drives her to plan Duncan's murder, revealing her ruthless ambition and willingness to abandon her morality to gain power. She calls upon supernatural forces, demanding that they "unsex me here". This command reveals her desire to reject compassion and kindness, which she associates with femininity, so that she can carry out the murder without hesitation. By asking to be stripped of her human tenderness, Lady Macbeth demonstrates that she is prepared to suppress her conscience and embrace cruelty to achieve her ambitions. Therefore, her

determination to plan Duncan's murder establishes her as a manipulative and ruthless character who allows her desire for power to override her moral values.

✔ Her manipulation of Macbeth

When Macbeth hesitates to murder Duncan, Lady Macbeth attacks his courage and masculinity to pressure him into carrying out the plan. She places her ambition above his moral doubts.

Key evidence: "When you durst do it, then you were a man" (Act 1, Scene 7).

Lady Macbeth manipulates Macbeth into agreeing to murder Duncan by attacking his courage and masculinity when he begins to doubt their plan. She challenges him, saying, "When you durst do it, then you were a man". This statement suggests that she believes Macbeth must prove his manhood by committing the murder, using his insecurities to pressure him into action. Rather than respecting his moral doubts, Lady Macbeth exploits his fear of appearing weak to persuade him to follow her plan. Her willingness to manipulate her husband reveals that her ambition has become more important than his conscience or the consequences of their actions. Therefore, Lady Macbeth's manipulation of Macbeth demonstrates her ruthless determination to achieve power, even at the expense of her husband's moral integrity.

✔ Her role in concealing the crime

Lady Macbeth helps Macbeth prepare for Duncan's murder and advises him to hide his guilt behind a welcoming appearance. After the murder, she helps manage the immediate consequences, demonstrating her willingness to deceive others to protect their position.

Key evidence: "Look like th' innocent flower, / But be the serpent under't" (Act 1, Scene 5).

Lady Macbeth plays an important role in concealing Duncan's murder by encouraging Macbeth to disguise his true intentions and appear innocent to those around him. She advises him to "Look like th' innocent flower, / But be the serpent under't". This metaphor contrasts the harmless appearance of a flower with the danger of a serpent, suggesting that Macbeth must hide his murderous intentions behind a welcoming and trustworthy façade. Her advice reveals her skill at deception and her understanding that maintaining a respectable appearance is essential to protecting their plans. After Duncan's murder, she also helps Macbeth manage the immediate consequences of the crime, attempting to prevent their guilt from being discovered. Ultimately/Consequently/Thus/In this way/This demonstrates that Lady Macbeth's role in concealing the murder demonstrates her cunning and willingness to deceive others in order to protect their position and secure their power.

*Explain how each example demonstrates Lady Macbeth's ambition, manipulation or dishonesty. Her later guilt does not erase her responsibility for the choices she makes.

**VICTIM** perspective:

Example introduction

In Macbeth by William Shakespeare, Lady Macbeth can be viewed as a victim because she is ultimately destroyed by the guilt and psychological consequences of her involvement in Duncan's murder. Although she initially appears strong and ruthless, her ambition, influence over Macbeth and

eventual overwhelming guilt reveal her vulnerability. Ultimately, Lady Macbeth is portrayed as a victim of her own choices and the destructive consequences of the pursuit of power.

*To argue that Lady Macbeth is portrayed as a victim, students could focus on three key stages in her character development, showing how she becomes trapped by the consequences of her actions.

**1. <u>Her rejection of her femininity and compassion</u>**

Key evidence: “Unsex me here” (Act 1, Scene 5)

Lady Macbeth can be viewed as a victim of her own ambition because she believes she must suppress her femininity and compassion to help Macbeth gain power. She calls upon supernatural forces, demanding that they “unsex me here”. This request suggests that she wishes to rid herself of qualities she associates with weakness, such as kindness and remorse, so that she can support the murder of Duncan without hesitation. However, her desire to reject these qualities reveals the personal sacrifice she is willing to make in pursuit of power. Rather than accepting her natural emotions, Lady Macbeth attempts to transform herself into someone capable of committing a terrible crime. In this way, Shakespeare presents Lady Macbeth as a victim of her own ambition, as her desire for power leads her to suppress her compassion and compromise her sense of self.

**2. <u>Her involvement in Duncan’s murder and its consequences</u>**

Key evidence: “These deeds must not be thought” (Act 2, Scene 2)

Lady Macbeth becomes a victim of the consequences of Duncan’s murder, as she discovers that the guilt associated with their crime cannot simply be ignored. She attempts to dismiss the seriousness of their actions, insisting that “These deeds must not be thought”. This statement suggests that she believes she can avoid the emotional consequences of the murder by refusing to think about it. However, her need to suppress these thoughts reveals that the crime has already begun to affect her conscience. Although she initially appears confident that they can move on without suffering, she underestimates the psychological impact of taking an innocent life. As the play progresses, the guilt she attempts to ignore becomes increasingly difficult to control. Consequently, Shakespeare presents Lady Macbeth as a victim of her own choices, as she becomes trapped by the emotional consequences of a crime she once believed she could manage.

**3. <u>Her overwhelming guilt and psychological deterioration</u>**

Key evidence: “Out, damned spot!” (Act 5, Scene 1)

Lady Macbeth ultimately becomes a victim of overwhelming guilt, which leads to her psychological deterioration and reveals the devastating consequences of her ambition. While sleepwalking towards the end of the play, she cries, “Out, damned spot!”, imagining that Duncan’s blood remains on her hands. The imagined blood symbolises her inability to escape the guilt associated with his murder, despite her earlier belief that the crime could be easily dismissed. Her desperate attempts to remove the imaginary stain suggest that her conscience has become more powerful than her desire to maintain

control. This contrasts with her earlier confidence and determination, revealing how deeply the consequences of her actions have affected her. Ultimately, Shakespeare portrays Lady Macbeth as a tragic victim of her own guilt, demonstrating that the pursuit of power can lead to devastating psychological consequences from which there is no easy escape.

## HOW TO WRITE LITERATURE ESSAY CONCLUSION

### GUIDELINES

1. **Restate the main idea / thesis**
   Remind the reader of your overall argument, but use different words than in the introduction.
2. **Summarise key points**
   Briefly mention the main ideas from your body paragraphs without going into detail.
3. **Show the broader significance**
   Explain why this matters. So what? How does it deepen understanding of the character, theme or text as a whole?
4. **End with a strong closing sentence**
   Leave the reader with something memorable — a final insight, reflection or universal idea.

## LITERATURE ESSAY CONCLUSION TEMPLATE

1. **Restate thesis in new words:**
   "Overall, [main character/idea] demonstrates that [central argument about theme or character]."
2. **Summarise key points:**
   "Through [point 1], [point 2], and [point 3], [character/author] shows [how theme is explored or idea is developed]."
3. **Show broader significance / insight:**
   "This reveals that [what the reader should understand about life, human nature, society, or the text]."
4. **End with a strong final sentence:**
   "Ultimately, [character/idea] proves that [lasting message or universal truth]."

## VILLAIN perspective:

**POSSIBLE CONCLUSION**

Lady Macbeth can be viewed as a villain because her ruthless ambition drives her to plan Duncan's murder, manipulate Macbeth and deceive others to protect their position. Her willingness to suppress her compassion and exploit her husband's insecurities reveals the extent to which she is prepared to go to achieve power. Although she eventually experiences overwhelming guilt, this does not erase her responsibility for encouraging the crime. Ultimately, Shakespeare presents Lady Macbeth as a complex but destructive character whose ambition and manipulation contribute significantly to the tragedy, demonstrating how the pursuit of power can lead individuals to abandon their moral values.

## VICTIM perspective:

**POSSIBLE CONCLUSION**

Lady Macbeth can be viewed as a victim because her ambition leads her to suppress her compassion, become trapped by the consequences of Duncan's murder and eventually succumb to overwhelming guilt. Although she is responsible for her role in planning the murder, she fails to anticipate the devastating psychological effects of her actions. Her transformation from a confident, determined woman into a deeply troubled figure highlights the destructive consequences of pursuing power at the expense of one's conscience. Ultimately, Shakespeare portrays Lady Macbeth as a tragic figure whose own ambition becomes the source of her suffering, demonstrating that even those who appear ruthless can become victims of their own choices.

# NATIONAL SENIOR CERTIFICATE EXAMINATION
# ENGLISH HOME LANGUAGE
# RUBRIC FOR ASSESSMENT OF LITERARY ESSAYS

**ASSESSMENT RUBRIC: NOVELS: LITERATURE ESSAY (30 MARKS)**

- Mind map may be used by candidate in planning but **no marks** are awarded for planning.
- Length of response: **approximately 600–650 words** in length. This is a suggested length as the cohesiveness and development of the essay will take precedence over the length. There is **no penalty** for length other than the development of the argument in the essay itself.
- **A word count at the end of the essay is NOT required.**
- **The rubric is not a check-list (tick-box) but should be considered as a guide when evaluating the Literary Essay.**
- **Half marks may be awarded.**

| Level | % | 30 | ASSESSMENT (Knowledge, Argument, Thinking, Structure) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 7++ | 100 | 30 | **FULL MARK ESSAY**<br>**(Extended Abstract Level)**<br><br>**EXCEPTIONAL**<br>**Highly eloquent response; exhibits academic rigour; strong individual voice; confident knowledge of text**<br>• The essay that is awarded full marks has greater depth and scope than a level 7.<br>• Candidate displays an exceptional ability to develop an argument that is academically superior.<br>• Resonates a sophisticated tackling of the topic.<br>• Quotations integrated with exceptional ability.<br>• Quotations and substantiation build an argument that is logically flawless and which exceeds expectations.<br>• The style of the essay is fluid and elevated.<br>• The essay is error free. |
| 7+ | 90–99 | 29<br>28<br>27 | **DISTINGUISHED/IMPRESSIVE**<br>**(Extended Abstract Level)**<br><br>**EXCEPTIONAL/ELEVATED**<br><br>**An impressive and distinguished essay; succinct; selects information to build an argument with sophistication; has depth of knowledge; dips into the text with confidence; consistent question focus**<br>• **Analytical concepts** developed with **precision**.<br>• **All aspects** of the topic have been addressed with **confidence and distinction**.<br>• Candidate displays a **thorough and impressive, in-depth knowledge** of the text, perhaps even drawing on moments of the text that distinguish the candidate's **superior, refined knowledge and understanding.**<br>• **Exceptional ability** to select information to develop a **succinct, carefully-crafted** argument.<br>• **Impressive/exceptional evidence** of candidate's original voice.<br>• Demonstrates **impressive individual thought and understanding** through analysing and developing **an arresting argument**.<br>• **Impressively integrates and elaborates** on specific textual references/evidence.<br>• Maintains **consistent focus** without deviating from the central concern(s) of the question.<br>• Candidate is able to **construct exceptionally critical, relevant and consistent connections** between topic question and argument, displaying **a convincing, impressive line of logical progression**.<br>• **Exceptionally lucid and logical**.<br>• **Thorough development** of literary essay structure; **focused introduction and conclusion.**<br>• **Excellent transitions** between paragraphs, which enhance the development of the argument.<br>• Writing reflects **an impressive command of register, spelling, language and punctuation**.<br>• Essay **signposted throughout,** indicating that the candidate has engaged with the question with a commendable degree of confidence.<br>• **Transfers** knowledge of the question in an **elevated manner.** |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 7 | 80–89 | 26<br>25<br>24 | **COMMENDABLE/EXCELLENT**<br>**(Extended Abstract Level)**<br><br>**SOPHISTICATED/HIGHLY DEVELOPED**<br>A **sophisticated** and **perceptive** essay that is **commendable** and **well-structured; substantiation from text enhances argument (which requires minor polish for a level 7+)**<br>• Argument is **thoroughly developed.**<br>• **All aspects** of the topic have been addressed with **sophistication.**<br>• Candidate displays a **thorough, accurate and confident knowledge of the text.**<br>• **Insightful** understanding of the novel.<br>• **Excellent ability** to select information to develop a **succinct** argument, which is **clearly focused and perceptive.**<br>• **Commendable evidence** of candidate's original voice.<br>• Demonstrates **sophisticated individual thought and understanding** through analysing and developing **a highly developed argument**.<br>• **Commendably integrates and elaborates** on specific textual references/evidence, although at times these could have been used with greater effect.<br>• Maintains **consistent focus** without deviating from the central concern(s) of the question.<br>• Candidate is able to **construct critical, relevant and consistent connections** between topic question and argument, displaying **a convincing, sophisticated line of logical progression**.<br>• **Lucid and focused,** although there may be a sense that further logical development could have enhanced this essay further.<br>• **Commendable development** of literary structure; **focused introduction and conclusion.**<br>• **Excellent transitions** between paragraphs.<br>• Writing reflects **an impressive command of register, spelling, language and punctuation, although there may be minor stylistic flaws**.<br>• Essay **signposted throughout,** indicating that the candidate has engaged with the question with a commendable degree of confidence.<br>• **Transfers** knowledge of the question in a **commendable manner.** |
| 6 | 70–79 | 23<br>22<br>21 | **COMPETENT/GOOD TO VERY GOOD**<br>**(Extended Abstract Level)**<br><br>**SKILFUL/PROFICIENT**<br>**An average response; proficient and skilful; competent and focused; accurate; sound argument; logical; dips into the text skilfully; minor lapses**<br>• Argument is **developed competently** and may have minor lapses.<br>• **All aspects** of the topic have been addressed with **conviction OR part** of the topic has been addressed with **depth and sophistication** (suggesting that if **all aspects** of the question had been tackled this essay could have been awarded a 7 or 7+).<br>• Candidate displays a **competent, accurate knowledge of the text,** although there may be minor gaps that do not impact on the strength of the argument.<br>• **Proficient** understanding of the novel.<br>• **Skilful ability** to select information to develop an argument, which is **mostly focused and competent. The argument in instances could have been developed further.**<br>• **Skilful evidence** of candidate's original voice.<br>• Demonstrates **competent individual thought and understanding** through analysing and developing **an argument with skill**. There may be minor lapses, which could have been enhanced with further development.<br>• **Integrates and elaborates** on specific textual references/evidence **skilfully/proficiently,** although at times these could have been used with greater effect.<br>• Candidate is able to **construct relevant and consistent connections** between topic question and argument, displaying **a convincing, proficient line of logical progression**.<br>• **Lucid and focused,** although there may be a sense that further logical development could have enhanced this essay further.<br>• **Competent development** of literary essay structure; **focused introduction and conclusion.**<br>• **Skilful transition** between paragraphs.<br>• Writing reflects **a competent command of spelling, language and punctuation, although there may be minor stylistic flaws/**An essay in this category may be one where the candidate displays an ability to develop an argument that is **highly commendable and distinguished** (which would result in a level 7 or 7+) but is hindered by major stylistic flaws.<br>• Essay **signposted throughout,** indicating that the candidate has engaged with the question with a commendable degree of confidence.<br>• **Transfers** knowledge of the question in a **skilful manner.** |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | 60–69 | 20<br>19<br>18 | **ACCEPTABLE/SUFFICIENT**<br>**(Multistructural Level)**<br><br>**SATISFACTORY/ADEQUATE**<br>**An acceptable, satisfactory essay that has broadly tacked the question. An essay that "does the job"; answers all aspects of the topic or part of the topic tackled well; broad and general in places but voice in evidence; accurate**<br><br>• Argument is **developed in an adequate manner** and may have **minor lapses/some generalisations**<br>• **All aspects** of the topic have been addressed **adequately, although these may be understood only in part OR part** of the topic has been addressed **competently,** suggesting that if **all aspects** of the question had been tackled this essay could have been awarded a 6).<br>• Candidate displays **adequate knowledge of the text,** although there may be minor gaps that do not impact on the argument.<br>• **Considerable** understanding of the novel- there must be a sense that the text **has been read and understood in broad, general terms.**<br>• **Adequate/sporadic ability** to select information to develop an argument, which is **satisfactory and competent. The argument in instances requires further enhancement and development.**<br>• **Some/sporadic evidence** of candidate's original voice.<br>• Demonstrates **adequate individual thought and understanding** through analysing and developing **an argument sufficiently.** There may be minor lapses, which could have been enhanced with further development/ the argument is **not fully sustained/ developed** throughout.<br>• **Evidence of** specific textual references/evidence that is **adequate/acceptable,** although at times these could have been used with greater effect.<br>• Candidate is able to **construct adequate connections** between topic question and argument, displaying **a satisfactory progression**.<br>• **Generally focused,** although there may be a sense that further logical development could have enhanced this essay further.<br>• **Adequate development** of literary essay structure; **satisfactory introduction and conclusion.**<br>• **Adequate transition** between paragraphs. |
| 4 | 50–59 | 17<br>16<br>15 | **MARGINAL/BASIC**<br>**(Unistructural Level)**<br><br>**SKETCHY/BELOW AVERAGE/UNDEVELOPED**<br>A **basic, undeveloped** essay that **attempts to engage** with the question albeit **limited and/or unsuccessfully in parts; has glimmer(s) of analysis; does not always dip into the text; padded with narrative; slight evidence of voice.**<br><br>• An **attempt to develop an argument,** although it might be lacking relevance in parts/**sweeping generalisations/narrow or inaccurate in parts.**<br>• **Simplistic interpretation/partly accurate understanding/narrow interpretation** of the topic/**vague** reference to the topic.<br>• Candidate displays **simplistic/flawed knowledge of the text** and the argument is drawn **simplistically. There may be glimmers of analysis and engagement.**<br>• **Broad, general** understanding of the text – there must be a sense that the text **has been understood in broad, general terms/comments show thought, but are not tied to the topic.**<br>• **An attempt** to develop an argument, which **may be successful in parts/ unconvincing argument, which lacks substantiation or development. There may be some substantiation used without flair.**<br>• **Slight evidence** of candidate's original voice.<br>• Demonstrates **sporadic/inconsistent individual thought and understanding** through analysing and developing **simplistically.** There may be lapses which could have been enhanced with further development/ the argument is **not fully sustained/ developed.**<br>• Essay is **padded with intermittent narrative and occasional argument.**<br>• Textual reference is **unconvincing at times and may be either inaccurate or flawed**.<br>• Candidate is able to make an **inconsistent attempt to use some basic transition words or phrases, resulting in a superficial progression on the whole**.<br>• **Marginally focused** with a sense that logical development could have enhanced this essay.<br>• **Introduction and conclusion** are simplistic and may not point to an arguable position.<br>• Writing is **simple, unadorned**/reflects **an inconsistent and limited awareness of register/inconsistent grammar, spelling and paragraphing.**<br>• Essay lacks signposting throughout/limited, superficial signposting.<br>• **Transfers** knowledge of the question **in a simple, basic manner albeit unimpressively and with limited success.** |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | 40–49 | 14<br>13<br>12<br><br>PASS = 12 | **SIMPLISTIC/SUPERFICIAL/INADEQUATE**<br>**(Unistructural Level)**<br><br>**UNSOPHISTICATED/ONE-DIMENSIONAL/LIMITED**<br>**A simplistic, superficial/flawed essay that struggles to engage with the question; evidence that text has been read; thin voice; narrative; just meets pass mark.**<br><br>• A **weak** response but still worthy of a pass.<br>• **Inability** to sustain a personal opinion.<br>• A **flawed argument or no argument at all /provides a simple answer to the question.**<br>• Essay **lacks clear and logical development of ideas.**<br>• Candidate displays a **simplistic knowledge of the text** and there are gaps in understanding and/or interpretation.<br>• **There will be areas in the essay that are problematic or illogical.**<br>• **Not much** evidence of candidate's original voice inability to sustain or develop an argument.<br>• Little or no substantiation or referencing/flawed substantiation or referencing.<br>• **Critical thinking skills used superficially, if at all.**<br>• **Reliance on narrative.**<br>• **Absent or ineffective transitions** between paragraphs.<br>• Essay **not signposted/ signposted inadequately**.<br>• Introduction and/or conclusion **flawed,** with further development and synthesis required.<br>• Writing is **flawed.**<br>• **Weak** command of spelling, language and punctuation.<br>• **Does not transfers** knowledge of the question and if it does, it will do so with lapses. |
| | | | **POOR/MUDDLED/VAGUE** |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 20 – 29 | 8<br>7 | **EXTREMELY WEAK/FEEBLE**<br>**(Prestructural Level)**<br><br>**INEPT/UNSKILLED**<br>An **extremely weak** essay; a **feeble attempt** to engage with the text at times.<br><br>• A weak, flawed response, which might be completely off topic.<br>• **Inability** to state a personal opinion.<br>• **Difficult to identify any distinct argument; unfocused.**<br>• Candidate displays a **poor/incomplete/flawed/ no knowledge of the text.**<br>• **The essay is vague, muddled and lacks focus.**<br>• Little/ no/flawed substantiation.<br>• Paragraph links **problematic.**<br>• **Reliance on narrative.**<br>• Essay **not signposted**.<br>• Introduction and/or conclusion **flawed/missing,** with further development and synthesis required.<br>• Writing is **marred by errors that impede understanding.**<br>• **Weak** command of spelling, language and punctuation. |
| 1 | 0 – 19 | 6<br>5<br>4<br>3<br>2<br><br>1<br>0 | **INCOMPETENT**<br>**(Prestructural Level)**<br><br>**LACKING ABILITY/INEFFECTUAL**<br>A **totally incompetent essay that displays no link to the text or the question.**<br><br>• This piece will not meet the requirements of the task on any level.<br>• Vague, irrelevant, flawed.<br>• Inappropriate response to the topic. |

# villain

(in a film, novel, or play)
A character whose evil actions or motives are important to the plot.

# victim

A person harmed, injured, or killed as a result of a crime, accident, or other event.
A person who is tricked or duped.
A person who has come to feel helpless and passive in the face of misfortune or ill-treatment.
*Consider the above definitions.*

**TOPIC**:

Analyse whether you believe Lady Macbeth is the villain, or victim, of this story.

[30]

Analyse **detailed discussion with evidence to prove any points made**

*Macbeth (Lady Macbeth)*

You believe **Own opinion but need to make a choice!**

Villain vs Victim **is she to blame or was she more affected?**

**Evil actions or motives important to the plot** she is bad/to blame

**Harmed / killed / helpless / passive** she is good / innocent

**RE-WORD**

Using your knowledge of Macbeth, specifically Lady Macbeth, decide whether you think she is the bad guy (villain) or if she is innocent.

Use your knowledge of her actions, motives, importance to the plot and her death to inform your answer.

PLANNING & PROCESS & PRODUCT

Lady Mac B -

Villain:
Victim:

**Actions:**
Motives:
*Importance:*
*Death:*

INTRO:

Text: In Shakespeare's "Macbeth"
Topic: it is often debated whether Lady Macbeth is the Villain or victim in this story.
Thesis: While it is undeniable that she plays a role in motivating Macbeth to kill King Duncan, she did not foresee that it would set off a chain reaction of events ultimately resulting in her own death, making her yet another victim of Macbeth's reign of violence.
Trio signpost - eg1: While her initial motive to secure the crown at any cost suggests she is the antagonist, her eventual guilt and realization of her wrongdoings provide redemption for her.

- Eg2: Despite her insistence on Macbeth killing the king, she never physically commits any acts of murder or violence, even going so far as to discourage any additional plans of murder she discovers.
- eg 3: While she plays an important role in initiating the plot of the story, we begin to see and hear less from her as Macbeth's own ambition takes control, with even her death given no more than a passing mention.

Thesis 2: While her initial motives were villainous indeed, it is her lack of action and agency throughout the remainder of the play that earn her the status of victim in this story.

In Shakespeare's "Macbeth"  it is often debated whether Lady Macbeth is the Villain or victim in this story. While it is undeniable that she plays a significant role in motivating Macbeth to kill King Duncan, she did not foresee that it would set off a chain reaction of events ultimately resulting in her own death, making her yet another victim of Macbeth's reign of violence. While her initial motive to secure the crown at any cost suggests she is the antagonist, her eventual guilt and realization of her wrongdoings provide redemption for her. Despite her insistence on Macbeth killing the king, she never physically commits any acts of murder or violence, even going so far as to discourage any additional plans of murder she discovers.While she plays an important role in initiating the plot of the story, we begin to see and hear less from her as Macbeth's own ambition takes control, with even her death given no more than a passing mention.While her initial motives were villainous indeed, it is her lack of action and agency throughout the remainder of the play that earn her the status of victim in this story.

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P (eg 1 MOTIVES + thesis)
e (explain how it relates to her motives)
E (Provide textual reference)
L (Show how the point made **links** to HER BEING A VICTIM - how the evidence you have provided proves your point - then cement position with keywords from topic)

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P - Lady Macbeth convinces her husband to secure his prophecy as king by insisting he follows through with their plan to kill King Duncan, but does not anticipate that this will begin his reign of violence of which she becomes completely excluded and ultimately becomes a casualty of her own husband's unchecked ambition herself .

e - While her initial motives to secure their position in society at any cost shows she is not completely absolved of any responsibility, the fact she plays no active part in any of the deaths, as well as her exclusion from all subsequent murder plots, show that while she encouraged him at first, her actions do not align with Macbeth's increasing thirst for power.

E - (DON'T just QUOTE - MUST engage/provide context & significance)

Upon hearing that Macbeth seemed to have additional plans to murder (specifically his plot to kill Banquo and his son Fleance), she asks what he is planning to do, making it clear she was not involved in his continued intentions of violence. He tells her to, "Be innocent of the knowledge, dearest chuck, / Till thou applaud the deed " showing he had no intention of including her in these plans but would rather she wait and be pleased with the outcome.

Her guilt, however, becomes so overwhelming it leads to a decline in her mental state resulting in nightmares and visions of blood whilst sleepwalking.Towards the end of the play we encounter Lady Macbeth walking through the castle whilst asleep, rubbing her hands together remarking that "All the perfumes of Arabia will not sweeten this little hand." revealing to us that her subconscious is tormented by the part she played in the bloodshed and violence to the point it feels as though the guilt of what she has played a part in has stained her flesh with the evidence of her shame.

L - Though her initial motive to secure the crown contributes to Duncan's demise, through her lack of action in actually killing the King, her exclusion from all subsequent murders as well as the mental decline she experiences as a result of her guilt, it is clear that she becomes yet another victim of her own husband's ambition.

**It's a formula…**

GREEN

TURQUOISE

PURPLE + PINK (x2)

YELLOW + RED

1. KEYWORD METHOD
   Question - Style of answer expected from you (Discuss / analyse / compare etc.)
   Knowledge - Where are you expected to find the information? (Eg: Midsummer)
   Restriction - What specific aspect are you being asked to focus on? (Love/conflict/character)
   Quote - What words seem familiar/ have we discussed in relation to this topic?

2. Re-write topic : Use keywords to simplify and understand the focus
3. Planning Content: Write down points relating to the focus & group similarities
4. Planning structure: Decide on 3 paragraphs (Each own idea for 1 of the points above)

| **RECIPE** | **ESSAY** |
|---|---|
| ***Ingredients List***<br><br>SPAGHETTI BOLOGNESE<br>2 onions<br>500g beef mince<br>1 Packet spaghetti pasta<br>*Salt to taste* | ***Introduction***<br><br>POSITION<br>1st point<br>2nd point<br>3rd point<br>*Reference Topic* |
| **METHOD**<br>**Step 1: Onions**<br>Peel the onion then chop finely. Simmer on a low heat in a pan until golden brown. *Add salt to taste.* | **BODY**<br>**Paragraph 1: 1st point**<br>**P -** State your point/ main focus<br>**E -** Explain it in more detail<br>**E -** *Evidence to back up your point*<br>*L - Link* |
| **Step 2: Mince**<br>Remove from packaging and fry on a low heat until brown. *Add salt to taste* | **Paragraph 2: 2nd point**<br>**P -** State your point/ main focus<br>**E -** Explain it in more detail<br>**E -** *Evidence to back up your point*<br>*L - Link* |
| **Step 3: Spaghetti**<br>Place a pot on the stove, fill with water and wait until boiling then put the spaghetti in for 10-15min. *Add salt to the water.* | **Paragraph 3: 3rd point**<br>**P -** State your point/ main focus<br>**E -** Explain it in more detail<br>**E -** *Evidence to back up your point*<br>*L - Link* |
| **Serving Suggestion**<br>Now that you have fried the onions, browned the meat and boiled the pasta, you have made spaghetti bolognese. Serve it in a bowl on a cold winter's night and enjoy it with family.<br><br>**Why not add carrots at the end?* | **Conclusion**<br>As you can see from the _____ P1, the _____ P2 and the _____ P3, we can conclude that _____ Position & reference to topic.<br><br>** Why no new information?* |

**QUESTION 2**

*"Often, a tragic hero's fall from grace is triggered by one decision that sends them tumbling down to their inevitable fate. One choice leads to another and before long, it is too late to turn back."*

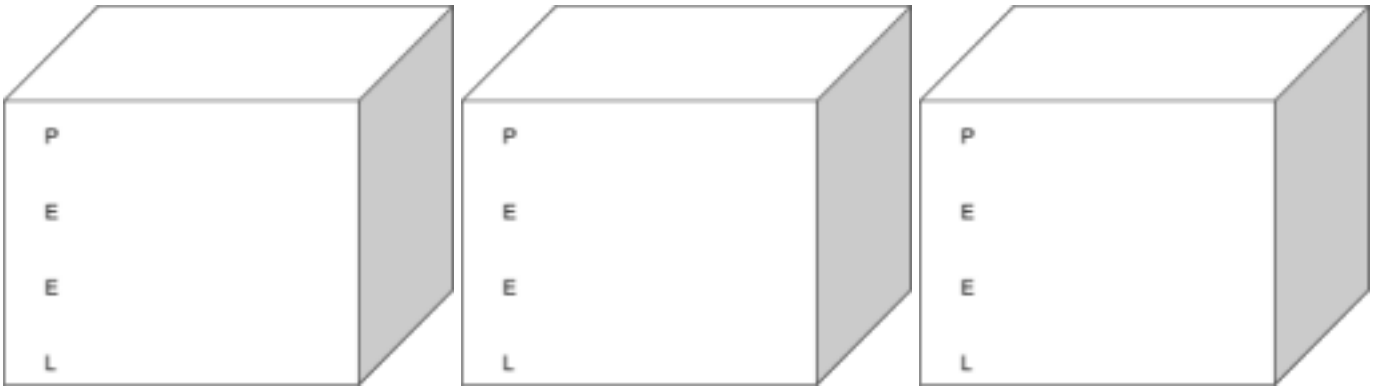
-Clara Smith

The character of Macbeth is an example of a Shakespearean tragic hero. Discuss the truthfulness of this statement. Your discussion should refer to the character of Macbeth and the events which occur in the play, *Macbeth*.

Quick essay Plan…

Thesis Statement:

Point 1:
Point 2:
Point 3:




INTRODUCTION:

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

P1:

L1:

P2:

L2:

P3:

L3:

How will I conclude my essay?

Topic:
P1 (L) -
P2 (L) -
P3 (L) -
Thesis:

CONCLUSION:

In William Shakespeare's tragedy Macbeth, the main character, Macbeth, experiences a dramatic fall from being a respected soldier to a cruel and hated king. At the beginning of the play, Macbeth is admired for his bravery and loyalty to King Duncan. However, after hearing the witches' prophecies, he begins to desire power and eventually decides to murder Duncan. This decision sets off a chain of events that leads to his downfall. Although Macbeth is influenced by the witches and his wife, he is ultimately responsible for his actions. His ambition, guilt and increasing violence demonstrate that he is an example of a Shakespearean tragic hero.

Initially, Macbeth is presented as a brave and honourable man who has earned the respect of his king. He is described as "brave Macbeth", which establishes his reputation as a courageous soldier who fights for Scotland. However, his character begins to change when he encounters the three witches, who predict that he will become Thane of Cawdor and eventually king. When the first prophecy comes true, Macbeth starts to believe that the second might also become reality. He asks, "Why do I yield to that suggestion / Whose horrid image doth unfix my hair?" This quotation reveals that Macbeth has already considered the possibility of murdering Duncan, even though he is disturbed by the thought. Therefore, the witches do not directly force Macbeth to commit evil deeds; instead, they awaken an ambition that already exists within him. This is the beginning of his fall from grace.

Macbeth's decision to murder King Duncan is the turning point in the play and supports the idea that one choice can lead to a series of disastrous consequences. Lady Macbeth encourages her husband to kill Duncan by questioning his courage and masculinity. Although Macbeth initially recognises that Duncan is a good king and that murdering him would be wrong, he eventually gives in to his wife's pressure and his own ambition. He admits that he has "no spur / To prick the sides of my intent, but only / Vaulting ambition". This metaphor suggests that ambition is his only real motivation for committing the murder. Macbeth understands that his desire for power is dangerous, yet he chooses to act on it regardless. By murdering Duncan, he betrays his king and abandons the honour that once defined him. This decision cannot easily be reversed, as Macbeth must now deal with the consequences of his crime.

Furthermore, Macbeth's first murder leads him to commit more violent acts in an attempt to protect his position. After becoming king, he fears that Banquo's descendants will inherit the throne, as the witches predicted. Macbeth therefore arranges for Banquo to be murdered. Unlike Duncan's murder, which requires considerable persuasion, this crime is planned by Macbeth himself. He explains that he is "in blood / Stepp'd in so far" that returning would be as difficult as continuing. This image suggests that Macbeth feels trapped by the violence he has committed. Rather than confessing his crimes or attempting to change his behaviour, he chooses to continue killing in order to maintain his power. His decision to murder Duncan has therefore created a pattern of behaviour in which one crime leads to another. Macbeth becomes increasingly ruthless, showing how his original ambition has developed into tyranny.

In addition, Macbeth's actions lead to his mental and emotional destruction. Before murdering Duncan, Macbeth experiences fear and guilt, imagining a dagger before him and later hearing a voice cry, "Sleep no more! Macbeth does murder sleep." Sleep represents peace and innocence, which Macbeth has sacrificed through his actions. Although he becomes king, he is unable to enjoy the happiness and security he expected power to bring him. His guilt also contributes to his growing paranoia, as he begins to see threats everywhere. However, as the play progresses, Macbeth appears less troubled by the violence he commits. When he decides to have Macduff's family killed, he states that "the very firstlings of my heart shall be / The firstlings of my hand". This demonstrates that he is no longer willing to consider the consequences of his actions before acting. His moral decline is therefore clear, as he has moved from being a respected soldier to a man who murders innocent people to protect himself.

Finally, Macbeth's downfall demonstrates the inevitable consequences of his choices, although his fate is also influenced by the witches' misleading prophecies. Macbeth becomes overconfident after hearing that he cannot be defeated by anyone "of woman born" and that he will remain safe until Birnam Wood moves to Dunsinane. He interprets these predictions literally and believes that he is almost invincible. However, Malcolm's soldiers disguise themselves with branches from Birnam Wood, and Macduff reveals that he was "from his mother's womb / Untimely ripped". Macbeth's confidence is destroyed as he realises that the prophecies have misled him. He refuses to surrender and continues fighting until Macduff kills him. His death marks the end of his reign and allows order to be restored in Scotland. Although the witches contribute to Macbeth's false sense of security, he is responsible for choosing to trust their predictions and act violently to protect his crown.

In conclusion, Macbeth is an example of a Shakespearean tragic hero because his admirable qualities are gradually destroyed by his ambition and poor decisions. His choice to murder Duncan begins a chain of events that leads to further murders, paranoia and eventually his death. While the witches and Lady Macbeth influence him, they do not remove his responsibility for his actions. Macbeth repeatedly has opportunities to reconsider his behaviour, but he chooses to continue down a destructive path. Shakespeare therefore demonstrates how a single decision, when driven by ambition and followed by further immoral choices, can lead to a tragic and irreversible downfall.

# Why this essay would receive approximately 22/30

The essay reflects the competent/good to very good category of your rubric.

Literary Essay Rubric.pdf

| Assessment area | Why it fits the 21–23 band |
|---|---|
| Argument | It maintains a clear argument that Macbeth is a tragic hero whose ambition leads to his downfall. |
| Knowledge of the text | It demonstrates accurate knowledge of the major events, from the witches' prophecies to Macbeth's death. |
| Textual evidence | It uses relevant quotations and generally explains their significance, although some analysis could be developed further. |
| Analysis | It explains Macbeth's changing character and his responsibility for his actions, but some points remain fairly straightforward. |
| Structure | It has a clear introduction, logically ordered body paragraphs and a conclusion that returns to the topic. |
| Style | It is coherent and appropriately formal, but the expression and analysis are not consistently sophisticated or original. |

What prevents it from reaching 24–26?

- Some analysis explains what Macbeth does without exploring Shakespeare's dramatic methods and deeper intentions in sufficient detail.
- The discussion of fate and free will could be more nuanced, particularly in considering whether Macbeth's downfall is truly inevitable.
- Lady Macbeth's influence is addressed, but her changing role and Macbeth's growing independence from her could be explored more fully.
- The argument is sound but predictable; a higher-scoring essay would develop more perceptive interpretations of Macbeth's tragic flaw and the choices that shape his fate.

In William Shakespeare's tragedy Macbeth, the downfall of the tragic hero is not caused by a single act of evil, but by a series of choices through which ambition gradually overwhelms morality. At the beginning of the play, Macbeth is celebrated as a courageous and loyal soldier whose actions have earned him honour and the favour of King Duncan. However, the witches' prophecies awaken his desire for power, and his decision to murder Duncan marks the beginning of his transformation from respected nobleman to tyrannical ruler. Although supernatural forces and Lady Macbeth influence his behaviour, Macbeth is not simply a victim of fate. His tragedy lies in his awareness of right and wrong and his repeated decision to disregard this knowledge. Shakespeare therefore largely supports Clara Smith's statement, while suggesting that Macbeth's fate becomes inevitable not because he is powerless to change course, but because he repeatedly chooses not to.

Macbeth's initial ambition reveals the tragic flaw that will eventually destroy him, despite his admirable reputation as a soldier. At the beginning of the play, Macbeth is presented as a courageous and loyal man who has earned the respect of his king. His reputation makes his eventual corruption particularly tragic because he has the potential to remain an honourable individual. However, the witches' predictions awaken a desire for power that challenges his moral judgement. When Macbeth first considers the possibility of becoming king, he questions his own response to the idea of murder, asking, "Why do I yield to that suggestion / Whose horrid image doth unfix my hair?" The word "yield" suggests that Macbeth is already struggling with the temptation to surrender to his ambition, while the phrase "horrid image" reveals that he recognises the disturbing nature of his thoughts. Although he has not yet committed a crime, his willingness to contemplate murder indicates that his ambition is beginning to challenge his conscience. Thus, Shakespeare establishes that Macbeth's downfall begins with an internal struggle between his desire for power and his awareness of morality, laying the foundation for the tragic decisions that follow.

Macbeth's decision to murder Duncan is the turning point in his fall from grace because he knowingly sacrifices his honour in pursuit of power. Before committing the murder, Macbeth understands that Duncan is both his king and his guest, making the crime a betrayal of his political loyalty and moral responsibilities. He also recognises that Duncan has been a good ruler and that he has no legitimate reason to kill him. In his soliloquy before the murder, Macbeth admits that he has "no spur / To prick the sides of my intent, but only / Vaulting ambition". The metaphor of ambition as a rider who leaps too far suggests that an excessive desire for advancement can lead to self-destruction. Significantly, Macbeth identifies his own tragic flaw before acting, demonstrating that he is aware of the danger but chooses to ignore it. Although Lady Macbeth questions his courage and encourages him to proceed, Macbeth ultimately makes the decision himself. His murder of Duncan therefore represents more than an individual act of violence: it marks the moment when Macbeth consciously abandons the moral principles that once defined him. This supports the statement that one decision can initiate a tragic downfall, as Macbeth's choice to murder Duncan destroys his innocence and creates consequences that he cannot simply undo.

Having gained the crown through violence, Macbeth becomes increasingly ruthless as he attempts to protect the power he has acquired. Rather than finding security in his position as king, he becomes fearful that others may threaten his rule, particularly because the witches have predicted that Banquo's descendants will inherit the throne. Macbeth therefore arranges Banquo's murder, demonstrating that he is now willing to commit further crimes without the same hesitation he experienced before killing Duncan. Reflecting on the consequences of his actions, Macbeth declares, "I am in blood / Stepp'd in so far that, should I wade no more, / Returning were as tedious as go o'er." The metaphor of wading through blood suggests that Macbeth feels surrounded by the violence he has created. His belief that returning would be as difficult as continuing reveals how he has convinced himself that further wrongdoing is unavoidable. However, rather than accepting responsibility for his crimes, he uses them to justify additional violence. His reasoning is therefore partly self-deceptive: he is not physically prevented from changing his behaviour, but he believes that continuing

along his destructive path is easier than attempting to recover his former honour. Macbeth's decision to continue murdering others demonstrates how his original crime develops into a cycle of violence, supporting the idea that each choice brings him closer to his tragic fate.

Macbeth's transformation into a tyrant becomes most apparent when he abandons moral reflection and acts on his impulses without hesitation. Earlier in the play, his conscience causes him to question whether he should murder Duncan, but his growing dependence on violence gradually weakens this restraint. When Macbeth learns that Macduff has fled to England, he decides to have Macduff's wife and children murdered, even though they pose no immediate threat to him. He declares that "the very firstlings of my heart shall be / The firstlings of my hand". The repetition of "firstlings" emphasises Macbeth's determination to act immediately on his thoughts, without allowing time for reflection or moral judgement. This contrasts sharply with his earlier hesitation before Duncan's murder and reveals how dramatically his character has deteriorated. Furthermore, the murder of Macduff's family strengthens the opposition against Macbeth and gives Macduff a personal reason to seek revenge. Macbeth's attempts to secure his position therefore have the opposite effect, creating further enemies and increasing the likelihood of his defeat. Shakespeare demonstrates that Macbeth's downfall is intensified by his repeated choices to use violence as a solution, until his ambition has transformed him into the very kind of ruler he once had the honour of opposing.

Although the witches' prophecies influence Macbeth's decisions, his downfall is ultimately shaped by the way he chooses to interpret and act upon them. The witches predict that Macbeth cannot be defeated by anyone "of woman born" and that he will remain safe until Birnam Wood moves to Dunsinane. Believing these predictions guarantee his survival, Macbeth becomes increasingly confident in his ability to defeat his enemies. However, the prophecies are deliberately ambiguous, and their apparent promises of safety conceal the circumstances of his eventual defeat. When Malcolm's soldiers carry branches from Birnam Wood towards Dunsinane, the forest appears to move, while Macduff later reveals that he was "from his mother's womb / Untimely ripped". These revelations expose the limitations of Macbeth's understanding and destroy his confidence in the supernatural assurances on which he has relied. Nevertheless, the witches never instruct Macbeth to murder Duncan, Banquo or Macduff's family; those decisions remain his own. Shakespeare therefore presents fate and free will as closely connected, suggesting that although Macbeth cannot control every circumstance, he remains responsible for how he responds to them. Consequently, Macbeth's fate appears inevitable by the end of the play, but this inevitability is largely the result of his repeated choices rather than the unavoidable fulfilment of the witches' predictions alone.

Macbeth's eventual death completes his tragic downfall, as he retains his courage but loses the honour that once made him a hero. When Macbeth finally confronts Macduff and discovers that the witches have misled him, he realises that the confidence which sustained his rule has been misplaced. Nevertheless, he refuses to surrender and continues fighting until Macduff kills him. His final resistance recalls the bravery for which he was initially celebrated, creating an ironic contrast between the soldier who once defended Scotland and the tyrant who has brought suffering upon it. However, courage alone cannot redeem Macbeth because his actions have destroyed his moral integrity and political legitimacy. Following his death, Malcolm's restoration to the throne suggests that order can return to Scotland, although the suffering caused by Macbeth's ambition cannot be undone. Macbeth's death therefore confirms his status as a tragic hero: his admirable qualities are ultimately overshadowed by his tragic flaw, and the consequences of his repeated decisions bring about the destruction of both his life and his reputation.

Macbeth is undoubtedly an example of a Shakespearean tragic hero whose fall from grace supports Clara Smith's assertion that one decision can lead to an apparently inevitable fate. His murder of Duncan initiates a sequence of increasingly ruthless actions that culminates in his death and the destruction of his reputation. However, Shakespeare's tragedy is more complex than a simple warning against one poor decision. Macbeth

is given opportunities to reconsider his behaviour, and his repeated refusal to do so makes him responsible for the path he follows. The witches influence his expectations and Lady Macbeth encourages his ambition, but neither removes his capacity to choose. Ultimately, Macbeth's tragedy lies in the fact that he recognises the danger of his ambition before pursuing it, only to discover too late that the power he gains through evil cannot protect him from the consequences of his own choices.

# Why this essay would receive 24+

The essay aims to reflect the distinguished/impressive band of the rubric, rather than simply offering more quotations or more detailed plot knowledge.

Literary Essay Rubric.pdf

| Assessment criterion | How the essay demonstrates this |
|---|---|
| Sophisticated argument | It argues that Macbeth's fate becomes inevitable through his repeated choices, rather than claiming that a single murder automatically determines his future. |
| Perceptive character analysis | It explores Macbeth's changing relationship with his conscience, ambition, violence and responsibility. |
| Integrated textual evidence | Quotations are embedded within the argument and analysed for the significance of particular words and images, such as "yield", "vaulting ambition" and "wade". |
| Critical engagement | It considers the influence of the witches and Lady Macbeth without allowing these characters to excuse Macbeth's behaviour. |
| Original thought | It explores the irony that Macbeth retains his courage at the end, but can no longer use it to recover his honour. |
| Logical progression | Each paragraph develops a stage in Macbeth's downfall, from temptation and conscious wrongdoing to tyranny and defeat. |
| Consistent question focus | The essay repeatedly connects Macbeth's decisions to the idea of a tragic hero whose fate appears inevitable. |
| Academic style | The argument uses precise analytical language and transitions that connect individual points to the overall interpretation. |

## The key difference between the 22/30 and 24+/30 essays

The most important distinction is the depth of interpretation, not the quantity of information.

Consider the difference between these two statements:

Competent analysis — approximately 21–23

Macbeth decides to murder Duncan because of his ambition. This decision leads him to murder Banquo and eventually causes his downfall.

Distinguished analysis — approximately 27–29

Macbeth’s murder of Duncan is significant not simply because it begins a sequence of violent events, but because it establishes a pattern of moral compromise. Each subsequent crime is presented as a means of protecting the power gained through the previous one. His tragedy therefore lies in his repeated decision to treat further violence as the solution to the consequences of his earlier violence.

The second version develops an argument about the meaning of Macbeth’s actions rather than simply explaining what happens.